

G-CAF

GovDigital Composable Architecture Framework

Volume 13

Governance Bodies & Decision Framework

v2.0

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Chapter 1

Architecture Review Board (ARB)

The ARB is the **Strategic Authority** for government digital architecture.

ARB Responsibilities

Area	Specific Responsibilities
Portfolio Strategy	Capability portfolio strategy; Build/Buy/Outsource for CRITICAL PBCs
Standards	Standard Contract version approval; migration windows
Exceptions	Dispensations and exceptions for non-compliance
Disputes	Cross-entity and cross-domain dispute resolution
Breaking Changes	Foundational PBC breaking change authorization

ARB Decision Transactions

Decision	Initiator	Product	Frequency
GD-01 Governance Framework	CEO/CD	Framework principles and policies	Annual / on change
GD-02 Investment Mix	CFO	Budget allocation (PBC Ops/Enhance/Build)	Annual budget cycle
GD-03 Risk Appetite	CIO/CISO	Acceptable risk thresholds by PBC tier	Annual / on event
GD-04 Resource Strategy	CIO/HR	Skills development and staffing plan	Annual
GD-05 Capability Strategy	CIO	PBC roadmap and domain priorities	Quarterly review

Chapter 2

Digital Design Authority (DDA)

The DDA is the **PBC Governance Body** responsible for all PBCs throughout their lifecycle.

DDA Responsibilities

Area	Specific Functions
PBC Architecture	Review and approve PBC designs; interface contract approval; standards compliance; integration pattern review
PBC Lifecycle	PBC Catalog management; gateway approvals; interface evolution; retirement governance; consumer notification
Technical Committee	Vendor PBC technical evaluation; duplication assessment; schema evolution assessment for vendor products

DDA Decision Transactions

Decision	Frequency	Product
GD-06 PBC Architecture	Per PBC submission	Architecture approval / rejection
GD-07 Interface Contract	Per contract change	Contract version approval
GD-08 Gateway Progression	Per gateway review	Go / Kill / Hold / Recycle decision
GD-09 Technology Exception	As needed	Exception grant or denial
GD-10 Change Authorization	Per change request	Change approval with impact assessment

Chapter 3

DDA Operating Model

Detailed operational guidance for DDA: stakeholder interactions, communication channels, and decision workflows.

Stakeholder Ecosystem

Layer	Stakeholders	Interaction
Strategic Governance	Digital Board, ARB, TMO, VRO, IV&V, Workforce	Regulations, strategic alignment, audit
DDA (Operational Hub)	Chairperson, Secretariat, Members, Technical Committee	Day-to-day PBC governance
Entity Layer	Entity CIO, Entity Architect, PMO	PBC submissions, gateway requests
PBC Lifecycle	Solution Architect, PBC Owner, Developer	Design reviews, contract compliance
External Layer	Vendors, Procurement, System Integrators	Technical evaluation, RFI/RFP

Chapter 4

Operational Models

Model	GovDigital Role	Entity Role	Best For
Centralized	Full ownership, operation, support	Consumer of PBCs	New entities; limited IT capability
Federated	Platform provider; standards enforcement	Operates PBCs within guardrails	Mature entities; need autonomy
Distributed	Governance and standards only	Full ownership and operation	Highly mature; specialized needs
Hybrid	Mixed based on PBC classification	Mixed based on PBC classification	Most common; balances control/flexibility

Model Selection by Criticality

Criticality	Recommended Model	Rationale
Critical	Centralized	Maximum control for differentiating capabilities
High	Centralized or Federated	Balance control with entity flexibility
Medium	Federated	Entity autonomy within standards
Low	Federated or Distributed	Maximum flexibility for low-impact PBCs

Chapter 5

16 Essential Governance Decisions

These 16 decisions represent irreducible commitments that must be made at appropriate authority levels.

ID	Decision	Authority	Category
GD-01	Governance Framework Direction	ARB	Strategic
GD-02	Investment Mix Establishment	ARB	Strategic
GD-03	Risk Appetite Setting	ARB	Strategic
GD-04	Resource Strategy	ARB	Strategic
GD-05	Capability Strategy	ARB	Strategic
GD-06	PBC Architecture Approval	DDA	Operational
GD-07	Interface Contract Approval	DDA	Operational
GD-08	Gateway Progression	DDA	Operational
GD-09	Technology Exception	DDA	Operational
GD-10	Change Authorization	DDA	Operational
GD-11	PBC Portfolio Investment	ARB/DDA	Investment
GD-12	PBC Vendor Selection	ARB/DDA	Investment
GD-13	PBC Authorization	ARB/DDA	Investment
GD-14	Exception Granting	ARB/DDA	Lifecycle
GD-15	Compliance Certification	ARB/DDA	Lifecycle
GD-16	PBC Retirement	ARB/DDA	Lifecycle

Chapter 6

Decision Rules

Each decision rule follows the pattern: RULE → ON (trigger) → IF (pre-conditions) → WITH (inputs) → DO (evaluation) → THEN (outcomes).

Gateway Decision Rule Example (DR-INIT)

Element	Specification
RULE	DR-INIT: Initiation Gateway Decision
ON	PBC proposal submitted for Initiation Gateway
IF	Catalog search completed; domain assigned; PBC type determined; criticality assessed; sourcing decision document
WITH	PBC proposal, catalog search results, classification selections, team/budget confirmation
DO	Validate completeness; assess reuse opportunity; verify classification consistency; evaluate risk
THEN	APPROVE (proceed to Design) / REJECT (return with reasons) / HOLD (pending additional info)

These rules ensure consistent, auditable governance decisions across all 16 essential decisions and 4 gateway stages.

Chapter 7

Framework Decision Log

Records the actual decisions that have been made — with rationale — so future practitioners can trace WHY the framework is the way it is.

DEC-ID	Title	Authority	Date
DEC-001	PBC-centric governance model	ARB	2025-01
DEC-002	Mandatory gateways for all PBCs	ARB	2025-01
DEC-003	Six PBC types (incl. Agent)	ARB	2025-06
DEC-004	Azure-native sovereign cloud	ARB	2025-03
DEC-005	NS-compliant modular framework design	ARB	2025-01
DEC-006	Federated governance with central standards	ARB	2025-01
DEC-007	17 architecture principles ordering	DDA	2025-06
DEC-008	Five standard contract types	ARB	2025-01
DEC-009	Composable over microservices	ARB	2025-01
DEC-010	Schema evolution rules (tolerant reader)	DDA	2025-03
DEC-011	Community-driven framework evolution (RFC)	ARB	2026-02

Chapter 8

Investment Governance

Three-level investment hierarchy connecting strategic budget to PBC delivery.

Level	Decision	Authority	Description
Strategic	GD-02: PBC Investment Mix	ARB	Total PBC budget split: Ops (50-65%), Enhance (20-30%), Build (15-20%)
Portfolio	GD-11: PBC Portfolio Investment	ARB	Domain-level funding allocation across PBC portfolios
Individual	GD-13: PBC Authorization	DDA	Individual PBC go/no-go decisions with budget approval

Chapter 9

Procurement Governance

PBC Gateway	Procurement Stage	DDA Deliverable
Initiation	Pre-procurement	Technical requirements package
(Technical Eval)	RFP/RFQ	Technical Evaluation Report
Design	Contract award	Architecture approval
Go-Live	Go-Live / acceptance	Production clearance

Standardized artifacts include G-CAF SoW Template (PBC scope, interface contracts, schema evolution), G-CAF BOQ Template (licensing, integration, ACL, support tiers). Source code ownership transferred to DGE; code development transparency required; clear licensing model documented.

Chapter 10

Domain & Data Ownership

Government Domains (Organizational)

Domain	Description	Responsible Entity
GovData	Data management, analytics, AI/ML	Data and AI Office
GovAI	AI services and intelligent automation	Data and AI Office
GovOps	Internal operations	Operations Office
GovCitizen	Citizen-facing services	Citizen Services Authority
GovBusiness	Business-facing services	Business Services Authority
GovCompliance	Audit, security, compliance	Audit and Compliance Office

Domain (organizational ownership, CD-GOV) is orthogonal to Bounded Context (semantic model, CD-DDD). A PBC has both: domain assignment (who owns it) and bounded context (what it models). These change independently — NS compliance.

Federated Data Governance

Three levels: Whole-of-Government (WofG Data Committee → ARB, central standards), Department Level (Dept Data Committee → DDA, federated autonomy), and Team Level (Data Stewards, local data quality). Provider/Consumer RACI defines responsibilities for landing zone provisioning, central services, platform observability, PBC development, local data governance, and cost management.

Chapter 11

Framework Evolution

The EA Office is the steward of G-CAF, not the gatekeeper. Any practitioner at L1+ on the Contributor Ladder can propose a change.

The G-CAF Way — 5 Principles

Principle	Description
Transparent	All proposals, discussions, decisions visible to entire community
Inclusive	Any practitioner can propose; evaluation based on merit, not seniority
Evidence-Based	Must cite real-world experience: "We tried this in Entity X and found..."
Reversible	Prefer reversible changes; irreversible require higher scrutiny
Documented	Every accepted change recorded with rationale for future practitioners

RFC Process: Submit proposal → Community review → Guild evaluation → DDA/ARB decision → Implementation → Changelog update. Change categories: Strategic (ARB), Standard (DDA), Correction (EA Office).

Chapter 12

Deployment Governance

Hub-Spoke Topology

Enterprise Hub (Central/GovDigital): shared services — identity, networking, DNS, firewall, bastion, SIEM, Key Vault. Spokes (per entity): entity VNet, entity PBCs, entity data, local Key Vault. Trust via peering from hub to spokes.

Subscription Governance

Management Group hierarchy: Government Root → Platform (management, connectivity, identity) → Landing Zones (production, non-production per entity) → Sandbox → Decommissioned. Mandatory policies at Government Root: UAE IA Baseline, CIS Benchmark, Allowed Locations, Encryption.

Cross-Tenant Trust Patterns

Pattern	Use Case	Identity Flow
B2B Guest	User collaboration	Guest in target tenant
Service Principal	Service integration	App registration
Managed Identity	Workload identity	Federated credentials
Private Link	Secure data sharing	Network-level (no identity)

Chapter 13

Ownership Map, Transactions & Requirements Registry

Ownership Map

Every G-CAF concern is mapped to its owner across 8 architectural layers (L0 Governance through L7 Cloud), 4 core contracts (Security → Cyber Security, Data → Data Office, Integration → Integration Team, NFR → Platform Team), and supporting modules.

Execution Transactions (M-Layer)

16 execution transactions (MT-01 to MT-16) implement the PBC lifecycle: PBC Build (developing, contract implementing, golden path using, IDP onboarding), PBC Deploy (registering, gateway submitting, environment provisioning, promoting), PBC Operate (monitoring, incident responding, SLA reporting, consumer supporting), PBC Retire (deprecating, migrating, deregistering, archiving).

Information Transactions (I-Layer)

40 information transactions (IT-01 to IT-40) produce assessments and monitoring data: PBC Assessments (portfolio assessing, reuse scoring, maturity evaluating, readiness assessing), Contract Monitoring (security compliance, data compliance, integration compliance, NFR compliance), Gateway Intelligence (readiness scoring, evidence checking), and Provider-Consumer Monitoring (SLA tracking, satisfaction measuring, consumption reporting).

Requirements Registry

The single source of truth for all G-CAF requirements. Each requirement exists ONCE with a REQ-ID (e.g., REQ-ARC-001). All assessment criteria, gateway checklists, and compliance checks reference this registry. Domains: Architecture (ARC), Integration (INT), Data (DAT), Security (SEC), Operations (OPS), Governance (GOV), Experience (EXP).

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